PRACTICAL WORKBOOK

AI for Budgeting

A gentler relationship with money math.

A low-shame workbook for making the invisible visible: your bills, your patterns, your priorities, and the next small step.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 Ground rules and privacy first
02 A one-page money snapshot
03 Bills, subscriptions, and leaks
04 Plain-English planning prompts
05 Debt, savings, and tight months

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Start with a money map

A budget is not a moral report card. It is a plan for directing money before the month directs it for you. You do not need a perfect spreadsheet to begin; you need a rough picture and a little honesty.

Rough is enough

Round to the nearest dollar or ten. Use one normal-ish month. Chasing exact cents can become a magnificent way to avoid the actual plan.

AI is not your advisor

It can organize, explain, and calculate. It does not know your whole life, current local programs, or your real risk tolerance. Verify important numbers and use a qualified human for advice.

Keep access out

Never give a chatbot your bank login, card number, routing number, government ID, or security answers. Use totals and categories instead.

WATCH OUT

This is education, not financial advice

Tax, investment, debt, benefits, and legal decisions depend on facts an AI cannot verify. For those, use a qualified professional, a nonprofit credit counselor, or an official government source. For cash-flow organization, a simple plan and a careful calculator can still help.

What AI can and cannot do here

- **Can help:** group categories, draft a meal plan around a number, explain a confusing fee in plain English, build a bill checklist, compare debt payoff arithmetic, or practice a call with a service provider.
- **Cannot do:** guarantee an outcome, know today's rates and rules, replace emergency help, choose investments, prepare your taxes, negotiate legally binding terms, or make high-stakes decisions for you.
- **Will sometimes do:** get arithmetic wrong. Check any number that changes a decision on a real calculator or spreadsheet.

TRY THIS

The first useful step is noticing

You are not behind because you need to look. A money map is information, not a verdict. Start with what is true this month, then choose one change that fits your actual energy.

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Your money snapshot

Use one normal month — not the most expensive holiday season and not your best week. Round generously. If a number is unknown, write `?` and come back to it. Keep account numbers and identifying details out of anything you paste into AI.

This month's rough picture

CATEGORY	AMOUNT	NOTES
Income after tax		
Housing (rent or mortgage, utilities, insurance)		
Food (groceries and meals)		
Transportation (fuel, transit, car costs)		
Health (insurance, prescriptions, appointments)		
Care (children, elders, pets)		
Phone and internet		
Debt minimum payments		
Other essentials (laundry, supplies, fees)		
Flexible spending (fun, dining, hobbies)		
Savings or buffer transfer		
Total spending		
What is left (income minus spending)		

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What this page does not mean

A negative number is not a character flaw; it is a math fact that needs a response. An unspent amount is not automatically “free” — irregular costs like car repairs, school supplies, and annual renewals need a home too.

What I want this plan to protect

GOOD TO KNOW

Use categories, not confessions

The AI does not need to know the name of the restaurant, the clinic, or the person you paid. “Food: $310” is usually more useful than a transaction-level story. If you use an AI tool for categorization, redact names, account references, and dates first.

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Bills, subscriptions, and the small leaks

Automatic payments are convenient partly because they stop asking for attention. This page asks for it back. You are looking for surprises, not punishing yourself for having a life.

The bill calendar

DUE	BILL	AMOUNT	AUTOPAY?	PAID

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The subscription audit

SERVICE	MONTHLY COST	LAST USED	KEEP, PAUSE, OR CANCEL?

Look in three places: your statement or payment history, your app store subscriptions, and annual renewal emails. A yearly charge can be easy to dismiss because it arrives all at once. Divide it by twelve before deciding it is “only a little.”

PROMPT RECIPE — SORT THE SUBSCRIPTIONS WITHOUT THE SHAME

Here is an anonymized list of subscriptions and rounded costs: [paste]. Rank them by monthly impact, flag anything that looks like an annual renewal, and give me neutral questions to ask before I keep each one. Don’t tell me to cancel essentials or make assumptions about what I need.

One small action

- ☐ Cancel or pause one thing you do not use.
- ☐ Put one annual renewal on the calendar.
- ☐ Check one autopay amount against the current bill.
- ☐ Ask a provider about a lower-cost plan or hardship option, if needed.

TRY THIS

Annual does not mean invisible

A $60 yearly renewal feels different from $5 a month, but it is the same money leaving. Notice the full amount, then decide on purpose.

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Categorize without oversharing

AI can be a useful clerk. It should not become the bank. Start with totals you prepared, then ask it to organize patterns — not to collect your identity.

Make a safe summary first

01 **Total at the source.** Use your own spreadsheet, paper, or bank's budgeting view to get category totals.

02 **Remove names.** Replace merchants, employers, clinics, and people with generic labels.

03 **Round the amounts.** The plan needs the shape, not the receipt level.

04 **Strip identifiers.** No account numbers, card numbers, addresses, SSNs, dates of birth, or security answers.

PROMPT RECIPE — GROUP THE TOTALS, NOT THE TRANSACTIONS

I'm organizing a monthly budget, not asking for financial advice. Here are my rounded category totals: [paste categories and amounts]. Help me group them into needs, flexible spending, and savings or debt payments. Point out clusters I may want to look at. Ask a question if a category is ambiguous, and do not guess missing amounts.

PROMPT RECIPE — ASK BETTER QUESTIONS ABOUT THE CHANGE

Here are my anonymous category totals for this month and last month: [paste]. Give me five neutral questions I should ask myself about the changes. Do not label spending as good or bad or assume you know why it changed. Separate the facts from possible explanations.

The short "keep out" list

FINE TO SHARE	KEEP OUT
Rounded category totals	Bank logins and passwords
A made-up goal like "a $1,000 buffer"	Full account, card, or routing numbers
Your own debt labels like "Card A"	SSN, tax ID, or security answers
Current minimum payments	Full transaction exports with names and addresses

WATCH OUT

Verify the arithmetic

Language models can produce a confident total that is simply wrong. Use a spreadsheet or calculator for anything that changes a real decision. AI can explain the math; you still get to check it.

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Build a plan you can live with

A plan that only works during your most organized week is not a plan. It is a hope with a spreadsheet. Choose one approach, keep it simple, and leave room for real life.

Four starting points

- **Percent-based:** Divide take-home pay into rough shares for needs, flexible spending, and savings or debt. The well-known 50/30/20 split is a guideline, not a law; housing costs and income can make it unrealistic.
- **Zero-based:** Assign every dollar a job until income minus planned spending equals zero. Precise and useful if you like detail; maintenance-heavy if you do not.
- **Pay yourself first:** Move a savings or debt payment at payday, then plan the rest. Only works if essentials already fit in what remains.
- **Minimum plan:** Cover essentials, one small buffer, and one goal. This is the version to use when energy or income is low.

PROMPT RECIPE — DRAFT A PLAN FROM MY ACTUAL TOTALS

Help me draft a monthly spending plan from these rounded totals: [paste income and categories].

My non-negotiables are: [housing, food, medication, transport, care].
My priorities are: [one or two things I want to protect].
Include a small buffer and label every assumption. Keep planned spending at or below income. If the numbers don’t work, say so plainly and show which categories create the pressure. Don’t recommend investments, tax moves, loans, or debt products.

My draft plan

CATEGORY	CURRENT	PROPOSED	CHANGE

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Make it survivable

- ☐ Put irregular costs — car repairs, school supplies, annual bills — in a monthly set-aside.
- ☐ Include some joy. A plan with no room for a $5 pleasure is more likely to break.
- ☐ Automate one transfer or one bill; do not engineer twenty fragile steps.
- ☐ Schedule a ten-minute review. A budget is a draft, not a contract.

GOOD TO KNOW

If essentials exceed income

Organization cannot squeeze money out of an income that does not cover basic needs. Prioritize housing, food, medication, utilities, and essential transport. Look for official benefits, community assistance, and nonprofit credit counseling. Be wary of anyone who requires an upfront fee for “guaranteed” help.

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Debt and savings, one line at a time

You do not need to solve everything today. Start with an honest list, understand the two common payoff methods, and give savings a small, visible target. This is organization — not a recommendation to take on debt products or investments.

The clean list

Use labels if you plan to ask AI for math. You do not need to paste creditor names or account numbers.

LABEL	BALANCE	INTEREST RATE	MINIMUM PAYMENT	DUE DATE
Card A				
Loan B				
Card C				
Other				

Two common approaches

Snowball: Pay minimums everywhere, then put extra money toward the smallest balance. It often builds momentum.

Avalanche: Pay minimums everywhere, then put extra money toward the highest interest rate. It usually saves more interest if rates and balances stay as you entered them.

Both depend on terms, fees, and your actual rates. Check each statement and ask the lender when a number is unclear. Never stop paying a required minimum to chase a cleaner spreadsheet.

PROMPT RECIPE — COMPARE THE MATH, NOT THE HYPE

I owe the following, anonymized: [label, balance, interest rate, minimum payment]. I can add [extra amount] per month. Compare avalanche and snowball payoff order and show your arithmetic and assumptions. Do not recommend loans, investments, settlement companies, or a specific product. I will verify every number with my statements.

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A savings target you can see

Use a simple division: **goal amount ÷ months = monthly set-aside.** If a month is tight, decide on the fallback before it happens. A smaller automatic transfer that survives is often more useful than a heroic number that does not.

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE THE SAVINGS GOAL CONCRETE

Help me break a savings goal into monthly and per-paycheck amounts. Goal: [amount and purpose]. Target date: [date]. Current savings: [amount]. My income is [steady or irregular]. Show the math, include a smaller fallback version, and list what I need to verify.

TRY THIS

Do not optimize on a broken foundation

A buffer for food and a working car may matter more than the mathematically perfect debt order. Ask a nonprofit credit counselor for help if minimum payments are crowding out essentials.

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The tight month

Some months, the plan is not optimization. The plan is protection. If you are choosing between essentials right now, skip the color-coded spreadsheet and start with the next right step.

Minimum mode

- ☐ **Cover the essentials first:** housing, food, medication, utilities, essential transport, and required minimum payments.
- ☐ **Contact one bill provider before a payment is missed.** Ask about hardship plans, extensions, or lower-cost options. Get the agreement in writing.
- ☐ **Use what you have.** Plan a few simple meals around food already at home.
- ☐ **Pause one nonessential expense** rather than trying to cancel everything at once.
- ☐ **Avoid payday loans, crypto "fixes," and anyone who asks for an upfront fee** for guaranteed help. If an offer creates more pressure, walk away and ask a trusted human.
- ☐ **Ask for official help.** In the US, 211 connects callers to community services; state benefits portals and nonprofit credit counselors may also help. Confirm fees and credentials.

PROMPT RECIPE — PLAN THE NEXT TWO WEEKS, HONESTLY

The next two weeks are tight. Here are my fixed obligations and the money available: [rounded totals, no account details]. Help me order essential payments and plan three low-cost meals from what I have. Show where the plan is unrealistic. Do not suggest borrowing, investing, skipping essential medical care, or using a high-cost product. End with one realistic phone call or official resource I should check.

The low-energy versions

Five minutes

List the next bill due. Pause one subscription. Choose one simple meal.

Fifteen minutes

Write your five biggest spending categories. Check one autopay. Put a reminder for the next due date.

Thirty minutes

Fill in the money snapshot. Choose one protection for the next thirty days: a bill call, a food plan, or a small buffer.

GOOD TO KNOW

You do not have to explain your dignity

Asking a utility, lender, clinic, or benefits office for help is not failure. Many staff have a standard hardship process. Ask what options exist, write down the answer, and keep your own record. You are allowed to need the system to work.

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The thirty-day gentle reset

This is not a get-rich month. It is a month of noticing, one deliberate change, and a plan you can repeat without dread. Mark what you actually did; leave the rest for later.

Four small weeks

- [ ] **Week 1 — Look.** Fill in the money snapshot and list recurring bills. No changes required.
- [ ] **Week 2 — Trim one thing.** Pause one unused subscription, plan three meals, or set one bill reminder.
- [ ] **Week 3 — Protect one thing.** Move a small amount to a buffer, check one debt statement, or contact one provider about a better option.
- [ ] **Week 4 — Keep one habit.** Review what happened, choose one repeatable action, and schedule the next monthly check-in.

The monthly check-in

PROMPT RECIPE — REVIEW WITHOUT THE SHAME SPIRAL

Here are last month's and this month's rounded category totals: [paste]. Point out the changes without calling spending good or bad. Ask me one question about each meaningful shift. Then suggest one small experiment for next month that does not require me to become a different person. Do not give investment, tax, or debt-product advice.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE FIVE-MINUTE CHECK-IN

I have five minutes. Ask me five short questions that help me notice what happened with money this month. Keep each question under twenty words. End with one small next action.

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What I want to remember

When a human is the better tool

Talk with a qualified benefits counselor, nonprofit credit counselor, or licensed professional if:

- essentials are consistently not covered,
- minimum payments are crowding out food, housing, medication, or care,
- you are facing legal action or eviction,
- you cannot tell whether a debt or benefit offer is legitimate,
- or money stress is affecting your sleep, safety, or mental health.

WATCH OUT

No AI bravado

A confident chatbot is not a safety net. If a decision affects your housing, health, immigration status, taxes, or legal rights, slow down and use a qualified human source. A printable checklist is a starting point, not a rescue plan.

ONE LAST THING · 05

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Gather last month's rounded category totals — never your account numbers — and fill in the money snapshot. Clarity first; changes later.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

01 AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

02 Beginner AI Glossary

03 AI Privacy Checklist

04 AI for Job Search

06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

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